DSEH004 · PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT AND EMPLOYEE ENGAGEMENT

Strengths or Weaknesses? Feedback and Strengths Based PM

Week 9 · Lecture 1 · Positive psychology, feedback intervention theory and the overuse critique

R K Singh
Senior Professor, Department of Commerce, Delhi School of Economics, University of Delhi

L1 · QUIZ 4

Quiz 4 opens now.

Weeks 6, 7 and 8. Phones go away once you submit. We begin the lecture when the quiz closes.

L1 · COMMIT BEFORE THEORY

Telling an employee clearly what is wrong with their work improves their performance.

True, false, or it depends on something you can name? Write one line before we look at the evidence.

Three traditions, one shared claim

SELIGMAN AND CSIKSZENTMIHALYI (2000)

Positive psychology

Psychology had studied repair of damage far more than the conditions in which people flourish. Seligman and Csikszentmihalyi (2000) proposed rebalancing the science.

CAMERON, DUTTON AND QUINN (2003)

Positive organizational scholarship

The same rebalancing applied to organizations: study what generates exceptional performance, not only what causes failure.

CLIFTON AND HARTER (2003)

Strengths based development

Clifton's Gallup program: a strength is talent multiplied by investment. Develop what is already strong rather than chase what is weak.

Shared claim: the highest returns come from building on what is already present. Our task is to test that claim, not to adopt it.

L1 · WHAT EXACTLY IS A STRENGTH?

Three definitions that lead to different systems

DEFINITION	WHAT IT IS	WHAT A PM SYSTEM THEN DOES
Clifton (Gallup)	Talent, a recurring pattern of thought, feeling or behavior, multiplied by knowledge and skill	Identify talents, then invest training and role fit where talent is high
VIA (Peterson and Seligman)	24 character strengths grouped under six virtues; moral as well as functional	Help people use signature strengths in daily work
Linley	A preexisting capacity that is authentic and energizing to use, and enables performance	Ask what energizes, not only what scores high

Only the third definition separates what a person does well from what a person wants to keep doing. That gap matters for BT 2026400.

Clifton and Harter (2003); Peterson and Seligman (2004); Linley (2008)

Kluger and DeNisi (1996): feedback intervention theory

What they pooled

607 effect sizes from 131 papers, covering 23,663 observations of feedback on performance.

The average

A positive average effect, d = 0.41. Feedback helps on average.

The finding that matters

In over one third of cases, feedback **reduced** performance. The average hides a large harmful tail.

Why it happens

Feedback moves attention. Toward the task, performance rises. Toward the self, performance falls.

Kluger, A. N., and DeNisi, A. (1996). Psychological Bulletin, 119(2), 254 to 284

L1 · THE MECHANISM

Where feedback sends a person's attention

LEVEL OF ATTENTION	WHAT THE PERSON THINKS ABOUT	EFFECT ON PERFORMANCE
Task learning	The details of how to do the task	Can help or hurt; detail can overload
Task motivation	The gap between goal and current performance	Usually helps; this is goal setting at work
Meta task (the self)	What this says about me, my standing, my worth	Usually hurts; effort goes to protecting the self

A weakness label, a forced rank or a public comparison pulls attention up to the self. The critique of annual appraisal is a theory, not a mood.

Kluger and DeNisi (1996); Locke and Latham (2002)

L1 · A DESIGN BUILT ON THAT THEORY

The feedforward interview and strengths based appraisal

1 **Story of success**
The employee describes an episode at work when they felt at their best and performed well.

2 **Conditions**
Together, name the conditions that made it possible: their actions, the manager's actions, the setting.

3 **Feedforward**
How close is your current work to those conditions? What would bring the next quarter closer?

4 **Goals from the gap**
Goals are set from that distance, so attention stays on task motivation, not on the self.

Kluger and Nir (2010), Human Resource Management Review, 20(3); Bouskila Yam and Kluger (2011), Human Resource Management Review, 21(2)

Read the strengths literature as you read Costanza

VAN WOERKOM AND MEYERS (2015)

What is supported

Perceived organizational support for strengths use relates to positive affect and in role performance.

GHIELEN, VAN WOERKOM AND MEYERS (2018)

What reviews conclude

Strengths interventions show benefits for wellbeing and engagement; performance effects are less consistent.

DESIGN AND SOURCE

Where to be careful

Much evidence comes from the vendor that sells the assessment, and few studies use controlled designs.

Ask of any strengths claim: who measured it, against what comparison group, and was the outcome performance or feeling good?

Strengths can be overused

GRANT AND SCHWARTZ (2011)

Too much of a good thing

Many traits follow an inverted U: beyond a point, more of a strength harms performance. Recall Warr's vitamins from Week 8.

KAISER AND OVERFIELD (2011)

Lopsided leadership

Managers rated highest on one side, such as forceful, were often rated as overdoing it; strengths and overuse travel together.

AGUINIS, GOTTFREDSON AND JOO (2012)

Weakness that matters

When a gap blocks the job, it must be addressed. Strengths first is a sequence, not an amnesty.

L1 · TELLING THEORIES APART

Same case, four theories: BT 2026400

THEORY	WHAT IT SEES IN A 22.5 YEAR QC SPECIALIST RATED 4.0	DESIGN IT IMPLIES
Deficit model	Gaps against a management competency list	Training toward leadership readiness
Strengths (Clifton)	Deep talent in precision and judgment	Invest further in the specialist domain
Feedback intervention	Any appraisal that threatens standing costs effort	Task focused feedback, no ranking talk
Inverted U	Rigor that can tip into resistance to change	Name the overuse risk with the strength

Synthesis of slides 4 to 10

L1 · COLD CALLS ON ROUND 5

Option 5A is a strengths assessment. Through which manager does it reach the employee, and what happens at 0.8 one to ones per round?

Name the mechanism. Name the theory. Name the evidence that would show it failed.

REFERENCES

Sources for this lecture (1 of 2)

Aguinis, H., Gottfredson, R. K., and Joo, H. (2012). Delivering effective performance feedback: The strengths based approach. Business Horizons, 55(2), 105 to 111.

Bouskila Yam, O., and Kluger, A. N. (2011). Strength based performance appraisal and goal setting. Human Resource Management Review, 21(2), 137 to 147.

Cameron, K. S., Dutton, J. E., and Quinn, R. E. (Eds.). (2003). Positive Organizational Scholarship. Berrett Koehler.

Clifton, D. O., and Harter, J. K. (2003). Investing in strengths. In K. S. Cameron, J. E. Dutton and R. E. Quinn (Eds.), Positive Organizational Scholarship (pp. 111 to 121). Berrett Koehler.

Ghielen, S. T. S., van Woerkom, M., and Meyers, M. C. (2018). Promoting positive outcomes through strengths interventions. Journal of Positive Psychology, 13(6), 573 to 585.

Grant, A. M., and Schwartz, B. (2011). Too much of a good thing. Perspectives on Psychological Science, 6(1), 61 to 76.

Kaiser, R. B., and Overfield, D. V. (2011). Strengths, strengths overused, and lopsided leadership. Consulting Psychology Journal, 63(2), 89 to 109.

REFERENCES

Sources for this lecture (2 of 2)

Kluger, A. N., and DeNisi, A. (1996). The effects of feedback interventions on performance. Psychological Bulletin, 119(2), 254 to 284.

Kluger, A. N., and Nir, D. (2010). The feedforward interview. Human Resource Management Review, 20(3), 235 to 246.

Linley, A. (2008). Average to A+: Realising Strengths in Yourself and Others. CAPP Press.

Locke, E. A., and Latham, G. P. (2002). Building a practically useful theory of goal setting and task motivation. American Psychologist, 57(9), 705 to 717.

Peterson, C., and Seligman, M. E. P. (2004). Character Strengths and Virtues. Oxford University Press.

Seligman, M. E. P., and Csikszentmihalyi, M. (2000). Positive psychology: An introduction. American Psychologist, 55(1), 5 to 14.

van Woerkom, M., and Meyers, M. C. (2015). My strengths count! Human Resource Management, 54(1), 81 to 103.